Part 1 — Problem Framing

Problem C: Competitive Intelligence | upGrad

1. Problem Definition

Problem: In India's competitive online higher-education market, upGrad needs a fast, reliable view of what competitors are doing across pricing, programs, positioning, and marketing. Information is fragmented across websites, program brochures, and advertising platforms, making consistent comparisons time-consuming and difficult to maintain.

Who faces this problem? Strategy, product/category, and marketing teams responsible for tracking the competitive landscape and supporting business decisions.

Current approach (assumption): Without visibility into upGrad's internal processes, we assume competitive research involves manually reviewing competitor websites, program brochures, and advertising libraries, then consolidating findings into reports. This process can be time-consuming and vulnerable to outdated, inconsistent, or incomplete information.

Initial scope: Analyze Great Learning, Simplilearn, and Emeritus against upGrad across two Indian program categories: Data Science & Analytics and Executive / General Management.

Desired output: A standardized, evidence-backed competitive intelligence brief comparing competitors across pricing, programs, positioning, and marketing, with relevant differences highlighted, traceable sources, and clear verification status.

2. Success Metrics

Primary Metric — Time to produce a verified competitor brief

Target: ≥70% reduction in total research and reporting time compared with a manual baseline, using identical programs, information fields, and verification standards.

Guardrail 1 — Factual Accuracy

Target: ≥95% field-level accuracy across a manually verified evaluation dataset, covering pricing, duration, credentials, and other factual program attributes.

Guardrail 2 — Evidence Traceability

Target: 100% of material factual claims must include a traceable source and verification status. Conflicting, missing, or unverified information must be explicitly flagged.

All thresholds are proposed pilot targets, not observed results.

3. Why AI?

Competitor information is largely unstructured and inconsistently presented across different sources. AI is suitable for:

- Extraction: Converting program pages, brochures, and marketing content into structured, comparable information.
- Analysis: Identifying differences in programs, pricing, target audiences, positioning, and marketing messages.
- Synthesis: Producing a concise, readable competitor intelligence brief from multiple sources.

Where AI alone is insufficient: AI can hallucinate information, misinterpret pricing, or rely on outdated content. Source tracking, numerical validation, and change detection should use deterministic methods wherever possible. Ambiguous or conflicting information should be flagged for human verification rather than treated as fact.

Core hypothesis: A human-in-the-loop AI workflow can substantially reduce the time required to produce reliable competitive intelligence without compromising factual accuracy or evidence traceability.